

MODULE 31 / 40

Ruby-throated Hummingbird

*Archilochus colubris***QUICK STATS**

Length	2.8 – 3.5 in (7 – 9 cm)
Wingspan	3.1 – 4.3 in (8 – 11 cm)
Weight	0.1 – 0.2 oz (2.4 – 6.1 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 3–5 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Ruby-throated Hummingbird is the only hummingbird that breeds in eastern North America — a gem of iridescent emerald and ruby that seems too brilliant and too small to be real. Weighing less than a penny, it beats its wings 53 times per second in normal flight and up to 200 times per second in a courtship dive, generating the characteristic humming sound that gives the family its name. It is a physiological marvel: its heart beats up to 1,260 times per minute during flight, and it enters torpor each night — dropping its body temperature dramatically to conserve energy — yet crosses the Gulf of Mexico in a single non-stop flight of 500 miles during migration.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Ruby-throated Hummingbird breeds across eastern North America, from southern Canada south through the entire eastern United States to the Gulf Coast and into Central America. It winters from Mexico through Central America. It inhabits forest edges, gardens, orchards, and any open area with flowering plants. It shows a particular preference for tubular red and orange flowers: trumpet vine, cardinal flower, bee balm, and salvia. It arrives in the East in late April and departs by early October.

DIET & FEEDING

- Nectar — from both flowers and hummingbird feeders (4:1 water:sugar solution)
- Small insects and spiders — essential protein, especially for females and nestlings
- Tree sap from sapsucker wells — used during early spring before flowers bloom
- Trumpet vine, cardinal flower, bee balm, columbine, salvia nectar
- Gnats and small flies caught in aerial sallies
- Never use red dye in feeders — plain sugar water is safest

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Ruby-throated Hummingbirds are fiercely territorial and largely solitary. Males defend feeding territories with aggressive aerial chases, driving away rival males and often females as well. Their courtship display is spectacular: the male performs pendulum-like U-shaped or figure-eight dives in front of a perched female, the rush of air through the tail feathers creating a distinctive chirping sound. Outside the breeding season individuals are independent and non-social. They have extraordinary spatial memory, returning to the exact same feeders and flowers year after year within days of their spring arrival date.

NESTING & BREEDING

The female builds a tiny, exquisite cup nest the size of a large thimble, constructed from plant down and bud scales bound together with spider silk — which allows the nest to expand as the nestlings grow. It is camouflaged with lichens on the outside and placed on a downward-sloping branch. She lays 2 white eggs the size of small jellybeans and incubates them alone for 11–16 days. She feeds the nestlings regurgitated nectar and insects. Young fledge at 18–22 days. The male plays no role in nesting.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Ruby-throated Hummingbird's primary sound is its wing hum — the rapid wingbeats produce a distinctive buzzing tone that varies with flight speed and behavior. Vocal calls are a rapid, chittering "chee-dit" and a series of sharp chips used in aggressive encounters. Males produce a distinctive tail-chirp during courtship dives. The species has no true song.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
----------------	---------------	-------------------	--------

The Ruby-throated Hummingbird population is estimated at 34 million individuals and is broadly stable. It is one of the few migratory species whose range has benefited from the proliferation of backyard feeders and native plantings. Threats include pesticide use reducing insect prey, habitat loss on wintering grounds, and window collisions. Planting native flowers and keeping feeders clean are the most effective support actions.

FEEDER TIPS

- Mix 1 part white sugar to 4 parts water — no red dye, no honey
- Clean feeders every 2–3 days in summer heat to prevent mold and fermentation
- Put feeders out by late April in the East — males arrive before females
- Plant trumpet vine, cardinal flower, bee balm, and salvia for natural nectar
- Multiple feeders spaced apart reduce territorial aggression at feeding sites

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & crown (male)	Iridescent emerald green
Throat gorget (male)	Ruby red — iridescent, angle-dependent
Underparts	White to pale gray
Female — throat	White, may show faint streaking
Wings	Dark — blur at 53 beats/second
Bill	Long, needle-straight, black

COLOR ME!

Ruby-throated Hummingbird • *Archilochus colubris* • Module 31

